

week, due to the fear that the votes may go to Tamang. Of the seven crore votes cast, half were made from landlines. With landline calls costing Rs 2.40 each and SMS Rs 3, interactivity is creating a revenue stream that cellular operators are eyeing very closely—from all estimates, Sony TV and the telecom partners made Rs 18.9 crore just from the voting for the final. Telecom operators are looking at a future when these numbers are going to grow. After all, over 1.5 million mobile phone connections are being added every month, allowing people to confidently predict why some talented singers/interesting characters don't stand a chance—if it's curtains for Sumedha Karmahe of *SaReGaMaPa*, it's simple, Chhattisgarh has comparatively low connectivity. If a good singer

while cynics may argue that the best people don't win the talent hunts anyway, regionalism can also act as a tremendous unifying force. As Tamang's case showed, regionalism can extend beyond borders as well—in Nepal, for instance, they had to change the timings of their own popular talent hunt show, *Nepali Tara*, because it was clashing with *Indian Idol 3*.

Clearly, whether it is Tamang, a Nepali Kolkata Police constable from Darjeeling, or Paul, a Bengali settled in Meghalaya, regions usually considered to be on the fringes of the mainstream, have seized the opportunity to be heard and for their ambassadors to be seen. It's happened before, when Debojit Saha was voted the winner of *SaReGaMaPa Challenge 2006*,

"Welcome, *mehmaan ho hamarey. Kya hua, khush nahin ho* (you are our guests. Why are you not happy?)" and they reply: "*Kya aap apne desh main mehmaan ban ke khush rahenge* (would you be happy being guests in your own nation?)"

But the big question that is haunting talent hunt programmers is this: are they creating marketing chipmunks who then find it difficult to find jobs in the real world or truly talented singers who can take the place of talent hunt alumni such as Shreya Ghoshal and Sunidhi Chauhan? The case of Touqueer, still struggling to find a film career

AMUL VOICE OF INDIA, STAR TV
Number of Votes
10 lakh
33.1 lakh viewers*



ON A SONG: Finalists of *SaReGaMaPa* (above) and *Amul Voice of India*

*TAM figures for week ending September 15



like Aisha Sayed from Mumbai cannot make it to the top 10 of *Indian Idol 3* it is because Mumbai and Delhi may have 10 per cent of the mobile ownership, but they are notoriously unconcerned about parochial loyalties.

For Niret Alva, president, Miditech, which produced *Indian Idol 3*, the show was all about discovering small town India, whether it was Ankita Mishra in Kanpur or Paul in Shillong—ironically the North-east did not figure in the 14-city auditions for the show. Paul was shortlisted in Mumbai and Tamang was picked up in Kolkata. But

over Vinit Singh of Uttar Pradesh, again because of mass voting from Assam, and in *Fame Gurukul* in 2005, which was about the mainstreaming of Kashmir in the national consciousness (with Qazi Touqueer and Ruprekha Banerjee attracting a landslide 2.5 crore votes).

As Hemant Sachdev, director, brand and communications, Bharti Enterprises, puts it, the SMS and where it's not possible, the phone call, has become the community's way of standing out from a piece of geography. It's like the scene from the rainbow coalition film, *Chak De! India* where the hostel staffer tells the North-east girls:

or of Sandeep Acharya, the faceless *Indian Idol 2* winner, is typical of the hard luck stories that abound. Says *Amul Voice of India* director Gajendra Singh: "Reality shows get winners instant fame and it's very difficult then to go back to being patient."

The real winner this time though is not so much a person as the North-east, ignored by the entertainment-telecom behemoths. Its turnaround is best summed up by *Indian Idol 3*'s resident poet Javed Akhtar, who mentioned that the show's participants had won the *dil ka daaman* and *ghar ka angan* (heart and home). If there's one thing the *Indian Idol 3* has proved, it is that the North-east wants to be both.